



Olympus Camedia C-2

Characterised by the sliding door that covers the lens, the Olympus Camedia C-2 looks classy and champagne gold colour combined on a 2.14 megapixel CCD that images at a resolution of 1600x1200. A half-frame, half-shoot camera—there are very few manually overridden. It features vari-

ous flash modes such as auto, red-eye reduction, slow synchro and off. The white balance modes supported are sunny, cloudy, fluorescent, incandescent and auto. The camera has an 8 MB Smart Media card and is powered by a pair of AA batteries, but Olympus should have provided for Ni-MH batteries instead, as

the AA batteries tend to get used up very quickly. There is a 1.6-inch LCD screen that previews the image and also displays the menu through which you can control the various parameters of the camera. However, the menu structure is rather difficult to get used to. The camera has a USB interface to facilitate quick transfer of images to a computer. The package also bundles the Camedia software, which is used for image transfer.

Though manual settings are missing, the camera offers good functionality and provides for some high-quality photographs.

Price: Rs 18,000

Olympus Camedia C-2					B+
Features	▶	▶	▶	▶	▶
Ergonomy	▶	▶	▶	▶	▶
Performance	▶	▶	▶	▶	▶
Warranty & support	▶	▶	▶	▶	▶
Value for money	▶	▶	▶	▶	▶
OVERALL	▶	▶	▶	▶	▶

- + Simple point-and-shoot functionality
- No optical zoom, takes time to get used to the menu system

lost to the Fuji in reproducing the specular effect. The camera which did not manage to score anything here was the Benq DC300. It filled most of the image with light, therefore eliminating any specular effects in the scene.

Among the 2+ megapixel cameras, the Fuji FinePix A201 came out tops in spite of tough competition from the Olympus Camedia 2100 Ultra Zoom. Although all cameras managed to do well in these two tests, some models like the Nikon CoolPix 775 and Sony DSC-P31 performed below par in the test for gradation in shading.

The Resolution test: The second test for details was with the resolution chart (see 'Test Process').

In the sub-2.0 megapixel range of cameras, the one that stood out was the Casio GV-10. It managed to pick up four out of the five patterns of lines clearly. The Logitech 510, the Olympus Camedia C-1 and the Benq DC300 performed sub-par—all three picked out just two of the five patterns. The rest of the cameras in this category picked up three out of the five areas on the resolution chart.

In the 2+ megapixel category, all cameras picked up four out of the five patterns with the exception of the Casio QV-2800UX, which managed just three.

Warranty

Digital cameras are very expensive devices. To add to this, they are not going to be kept in the safety of one's home—they are meant to lead a life outdoors. Therefore, the chances of something going wrong are higher and

warranty and after sales support become very important. Unfortunately, we found that the after sales support offered by a majority of these companies is disappointing, in terms of the number of service centres and the number of cities in which they have authorised service centres. Also, all the digital cameras came with a standard one-year warranty.

The overall and undisputed winner in this category was Sony with a staggering

infrastructure of 97 service centres in 28 cities. Benq and D-Link also have a good service network each comprising of 22 centres spread across 19 cities. Most of the other companies had less than five service centres across the country in about the same number of cities. Companies such as Nikon and Fuji have just one service centre in Mumbai. With such expensive devices, it becomes critically important to have proper support for them.

Nikon CoolPix 800

This camera abounds with features and a plethora of options for controlling virtually any imaging parameter you might want to. Based upon a 2.11 megapixel CCD, this camera has a 2x optical Nikon zoom lens that boasts of amazing clarity. This was very evident in its brilliant performance. It supports a native resolution of 1600x1200 and was the only camera that could store images in TIFF format as well. It has a comparatively large 1.8-inch LCD screen and features numerous imaging modes such as matrix, spot and centre-weighted with multiple white balance and flash modes. The camera settings can also be manually overridden and it was the only camera in this test that also had a manual focus. The camera also features a mono LCD display that displays the current mode of operation of the camera. However, there is no USB support—you have to transfer images through the serial port.

The Nikon CoolPix 800 gives you plenty of options for fully automatic as well as manual operation—all these control options make this camera a great choice for the serious photographer.

Nikon CoolPix 800						A-
Features	▶	▶	▶	▶	▶	
Ergonomy	▶	▶	▶	▶	▶	
Performance	▶	▶	▶	▶	▶	
Warranty & support	▶	▶	▶	▶	▶	
Value for money	▶	▶	▶	▶	▶	
OVERALL	▶	▶	▶	▶	▶	

Price: Rs 19,560

- + Very powerful manual control for virtually every imaging parameter, brilliant image quality
- Serial interface, too many buttons for controlling the various features

